Know Whether Mom's Care Plan Is Actually Happening

Four prompts to choose a few things worth watching, work out who can actually see them, give every concern an owner, and write down what you still have no way of knowing.

Where you are

Mom has carers now, or she's in a facility, and there's a plan on paper. You can't be there every day. When you ask how things are going, the answer is “fine,” and you've started to wonder what fine is based on.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can name the handful of things you're watching, say who sees each one and where the record is, point to who's following up on every concern, and admit out loud which parts of Mom's care nobody is checking.

A one-page Watch List: What we're watching and what we'd see, Who can see it, What we have no way to know yet, Concerns and who owns them, and Questions for the care team.

Before you start

- The care plan or service agreement, whatever version you have.
- Your list of things you've been worried about, in any order.
- The names of the people you deal with at the agency or facility. Any one of these gets you started.

PROMPT 1

Choose a few things worth watching

WHY THIS MATTERS

A family that tracks everything ends up with a notebook nobody reads. Monitoring works when each thing you watch connects to something in the plan and someone could actually see it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The care plan, and your sense of what matters most to Mom right now.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother has a care plan in place and I want to keep an eye on whether it's happening. Here is the plan and what matters most to her right now:
>
> [PASTE THE PLAN AND YOUR NOTES]

> First, list every item in the plan that could be watched. Then help me pick a starting set of five to seven, favoring items that connect to something she cares about and that a person could see or hear. For each, write one plain sentence beginning “We would see” that describes what following the plan looks like in daily life. Where an item is medical, such as a wound, a weight, or a medication, write “for the clinician to define” instead of describing it yourself, and do not suggest any warning signs or numbers.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A short list, not a long one, with the medical items left for a clinician to define.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the short list to the person who knows Mom's routine best and ask if anything's missing.

PROMPT 2

Work out who can actually see each thing

WHY THIS MATTERS

You can't watch what you're not there for. Carers' notes, a facility chart, a neighbor who pops in: each sees something different, and some things no one you know can see. Silence from those places isn't reassurance. It's a blank.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your short list, and what you know about who's present, what records exist, and what you're allowed to see.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the short list of things I'm watching in my mother's care, and what I know about who is with her, what gets written down, and what the family is allowed to see:
>
> [PASTE THE LIST AND YOUR NOTES]
>
> Make a table with these columns: WHAT WE'RE WATCHING, WHO IS PRESENT WHEN IT HAPPENS, WHAT RECORD EXISTS, CAN FAMILY SEE IT, and HOW WE'D FIND OUT. Where I haven't told you, write UNKNOWN. Then list separately every item where no one we know can see it or no record exists. Treat “we haven't heard anything” as unknown, never as a sign that things are fine.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The items where the honest answer is that nobody is looking.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask the agency or facility what records they keep and how a family member can see them.

PROMPT 3

Give every concern an owner

WHY THIS MATTERS

Worries pile up: the cold lunch, the missed shower, the bruise nobody explained. Each got mentioned to someone. Few got assigned. A concern without an owner is just a worry with a date on it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your list of concerns, who you've told, and what happened.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the concerns I've had about my mother's care so far, who I mentioned each one to, and what happened next:
>
> [PASTE YOUR CONCERNS]
>
> Put them in a table: THE CONCERN, WHO WE TOLD AND WHEN, WHAT THEY SAID, WHO IS FOLLOWING UP, and STATUS (resolved, waiting, or nobody owns it). Then list the concerns with no owner so I can raise them again. If anything I've described sounds like an immediate risk to her, say so plainly at the top and tell me to contact the facility's nurse in charge or emergency services now, instead of treating it as something to monitor. Don't judge whether the care is good or bad.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many concerns have nobody's name beside them.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

For each unowned concern, ask one person by name to take it, and write down that you did.

PROMPT 4

Write the Watch List

WHY THIS MATTERS

The care team will have its own monitoring. Yours is different: a few things you're watching, where the information comes from, and an honest list of what you can't see. That's what you take to the next conversation.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've worked out about keeping an eye on my mother's care:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page sheet called OUR WATCH LIST with five headings: WHAT WE'RE WATCHING AND WHAT WE'D SEE; WHO CAN SEE IT AND WHERE IT'S RECORDED; WHAT WE HAVE NO WAY TO KNOW YET; CONCERNS AND WHO OWNS THEM; and QUESTIONS FOR THE CARE TEAM. In the last section, include a question asking who to call for a routine concern and who to call for an urgent one, and a line reading “Clinical warning signs and what to do about them: to be confirmed by” with a blank. Do not fill that blank, define any threshold, or comment on whether she is safe.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page where the blanks are as visible as the answers.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Bring the sheet to the next care review, or ask for one.

Watch against a baseline worth having

You can't tell what's changed without a clear picture of where Mom started. The care interview records her situation across every area of care and produces a Family Care Profile, which is the reference point the things you're watching get compared to.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›